No One Is Coming

The Matrix and the Rest of Us

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In the companion essay, "The Comfortable Prison," I passed along Baudrillard's complaint that the heroic story of waking up, complete with a chosen One, is itself a comforting myth. I presented it there as a point of philosophy. Here I want to take it personally. If there is no red pill, and no One is coming to rescue us, what is left for the rest of us to do?

The struggle under all the stories

Looking back over our arc, I keep coming to the same thought. In all of these stories, isn't the essence of the struggle maintaining, or finding, one's own humanity? Escape, revolution, and victory come second, if they come at all.

How hard that struggle is depends on how much you think the world we live in prevents us from fully realizing our humanity. In the preface to the course, I distinguished between control that threatens and control that entices. Put more simply, a world can control us through fear or through desire. *1984* leans on fear. *The Matrix* leans on desire, or at least on comfort. Most of us, I suspect, live with a mix of both.

Flawed people, not heroes

The Underground Man and Winston Smith are not heroes. They are flawed, compromised people. The Underground Man is spiteful, self-defeating, and often unbearable, even to himself. Winston betrays Julia, and in the end he loves Big Brother. Neither story asks us to admire them. They ask us to recognize ourselves in them, and to learn something by empathizing with their struggle and their failure.

The Matrix is a different kind of story. Neo is called to be the One, and his name is an anagram of the word. He has elements of Jesus: a herald who announces him, a woman named Trinity, a last city called Zion, and a death followed by a return to life. He also has elements of the Buddha: enlightenment comes from seeing through the illusion of the everyday world, and the child who bends a spoon with his mind is dressed as a young monk. Neo is a human being who passes through trials and comes out an enlightened savior.

And, fitting what attracts modern moviegoers, Neo also gets to kick ass in bullet time. I enjoy those scenes as much as anyone. But I notice that the most popular tale of defiance in our arc is also the only one that needs a savior.

The rest of us

The film does leave room for ordinary people, if you look for it. For most of the movie, Neo does not believe he is the One. When he visits the Oracle, he comes away convinced that he isn't. Whatever he becomes, he starts out as the rest of us: uncertain, unchosen, and mostly trying to get through the day.

Then there is Cypher, the man with the steak from the first essay. He is tired. He wants the struggle to stop, and he makes a deal to go back to sleep. In some ways, Cypher is the Winston Smith of *The Matrix*, the person who gives in. I find him the character in the film I understand best, which is not the same as admiring him.

None of us gets offered a red pill. Our choices look smaller. And yet, if Deleuze is right that resistance comes from "circuit breakers," small pockets where the network's constant monitoring doesn't reach, then small choices may be where the struggle actually happens. If no One is coming, the work of staying human falls to each of us, a little at a time.

Some real-life questions

These are questions I ask myself. You may find better ones.

- **Fear or desire?** Which controls you more these days: the news that frightens you, or the screens that please you? Can you tell them apart?
- **Your own Cypher moments.** When have you chosen the comfortable version of things, knowing it wasn't quite real? Was that always a bad choice?
- **What keeps you human?** What do you do, or refuse to do, that a system built to predict and please you would have trouble absorbing?
- **Waiting for a savior.** Do you find yourself hoping for a leader, a technology, or an event that will fix things? What would it mean to give up that hope without giving up?
- **Circuit breakers.** What are yours? A walk without your phone, a conversation with someone who disagrees with you, a book nobody recommended?

Looking ahead

Our next story, Ken Liu's "The Perfect Match," brings this down to earth. Its protagonist, Sai, is no savior. He is an ordinary young man whose AI assistant seems to know what he wants better than he does. With him, the question of keeping our humanity shifts from the movie screen to the phone in our pockets.